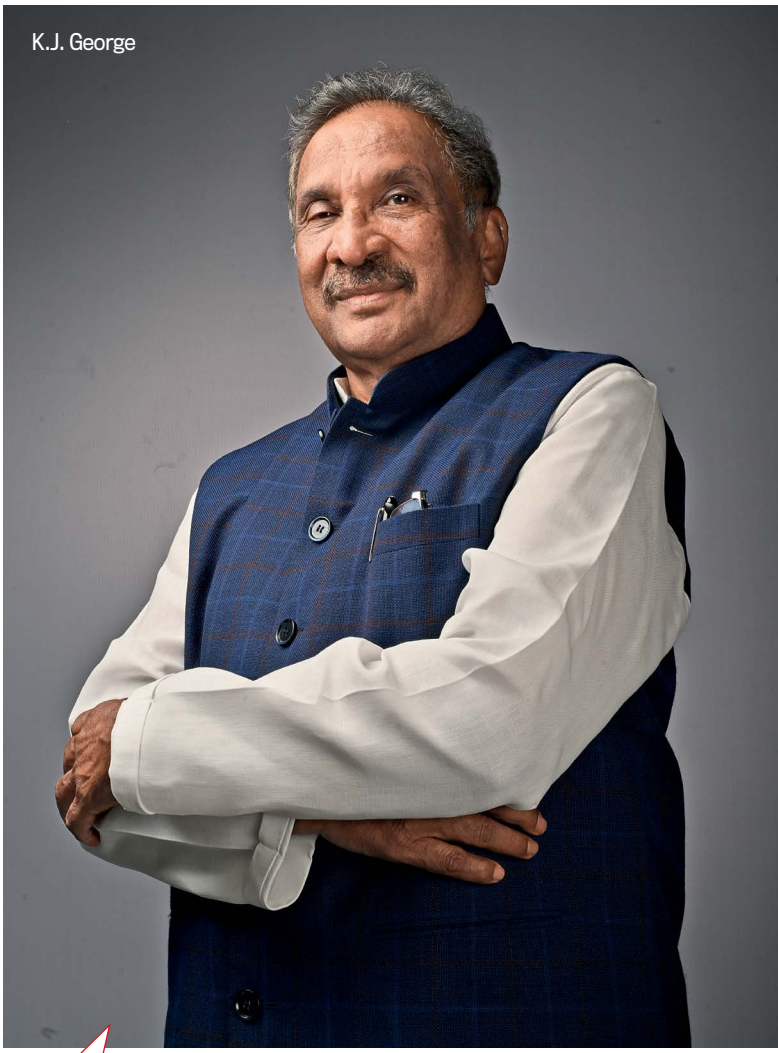
RENEWABLE ENERGY
KARNATAKA AHEAD

NOW, A RENEWABLE FORCE TOO

One of the earliest states to have electrification, Karnataka is also the pioneer of renewable energy production in the country


K.J. George

Power production started in Karnataka in 1902, under the then Maharaja of Mysore, Nalwadi Krishnaraja Wadiyar. As he discloses that nugget of information, the state's energy minister **K.J. George** outlines how Karnataka came to a pioneer in the field of renewable energy.

PAVAGADA SOLAR PROJECT

The Pavagada solar project (in Tumkur district) was started in 2016 (commissioned in 2018) during Chief Minister Siddaramaiah's first term over 13,000 acres and was the largest solar park in India at the time. The energy department is working on expanding it. It produces around 2,200 MW electricity. Officials and technocrats have pitched in, too. However, it could only come to fruition with the partnership with farmers. The state didn't acquire land for this purpose; it had taken it on lease from farmers. The farmers have come forward and offered the state another 10,000 acres.

PUMPED STORAGE HYDROPOWER

Today, 51 per cent of Karnataka's installed electricity generation capacity comes from renewable energy—the highest in the country. But how to store the electricity? Karnataka has got enough places to store the electricity as pumped storage. Excess energy can be used to pump and store water in reservoirs at higher altitude. Later, the stored water can be pumped and power generated—cheaper, renewable energy. Once the reservoirs have water, power can be generated within five minutes.

"I congratulate CM Siddaramaiah and Deputy CM D.K. Shivakumar for starting the Pavagada solar project. You have to see it to believe it. We have solar power and pumped storage hydropower. Now we are drafting a policy on green hydrogen"

K.J. GEORGE
Minister of Energy, Government of Karnataka

THE LATEST GREEN SOURCE

The future of energy lies in Green Hydrogen. Karnataka is drafting a policy for green hydrogen. To go ahead, the Centre's support is needed, along with necessary investment. With large-scale expansion of renewable energy like solar and wind power, a hybrid energy model is being created. Wind and solar energy can be used and stored, too, like in pumped storage. These are the main points of Karnataka's new model of energy. ■